

Five cheeses for the board

Five cheeses, each doing a different job: something soft, something nutty, something firm, something properly aged, and something with enough personality to divide the table.

CHEESE	ITS JOB ON THE BOARD	PUT BESIDE IT
Brie	Soft, buttery and immediately inviting	Honey, strawberries, walnuts
Truffle Gouda	Nutty, indulgent and easy to eat	Green apple, fig preserve, almonds
Manchego	Savoury, firm and distinctive	Quince paste, almonds, olives
Aged Cheddar	Sharp, crumbly and reassuringly familiar	Apple, chutney, seeded crackers
Danish Blue	Salty, bold and deliberately divisive	Pear, honey, fresh fig

A small rule we follow

You do not need an accompaniment for every centimetre of the board. Filling every empty space is the quickest way to make it look less elegant.

Leave some room around the cheeses. Build a few deliberate pairings rather than a pile of everything that technically goes with cheese.

AND ONE MORE THING Give the Brie around thirty minutes out of the refrigerator before serving. In a Delhi summer, closer to fifteen.